

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 121

REWORK v4 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Folate in your everyday plate, not just for planning a pregnancy

"Folate keeps your body making new red blood cells and repairing tissue day after day — a role that matters whether or not another pregnancy is anywhere in your thinking."

Why it matters now

Folate (vitamin B9) supports the ongoing production of red blood cells and the everyday repair of tissue in your body — a role that continues long after pregnancy and birth, and one that breastfeeding raises the requirement for. It's a different topic from the pre-conception folic acid guidance covered earlier in this series (Week 50): that's specifically about the run-up to conception and the early weeks of pregnancy, while this week is about the everyday dietary role folate plays regardless of your plans.

Leafy greens, legumes, citrus fruit and fortified grains are all dependable everyday sources, and food folate doesn't carry the same upper-limit concerns that high-dose supplements can — these foods help contribute to your needs across a varied week.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If you've been told you're anaemic: ask your care team which nutrient your results point to — anaemia has multiple possible causes, and the right supplement depends on which one applies to you.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Mizo cooking (bai, bekang/fermented soybean, sawhchiar, chhum han, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Folate needs don't disappear once a pregnancy ends. Your body uses it continuously for red blood cell production and everyday tissue repair, and breastfeeding raises that requirement further. Leafy greens, legumes, citrus fruit and fortified grains are all dependable everyday sources.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Bai, mixed vegetable stew with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked beans (1 cup stew, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with tomato and onion, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Bekang, fermented soybean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked soybeans) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Chicken curry, Mizo-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Food folate and supplement folic acid aren't quite the same thing

Folate occurring naturally in food and folic acid in supplements or fortified foods both count toward your intake, but they're handled somewhat differently by the body — food folate doesn't carry the same upper-limit concerns that high-dose supplemental folic acid can. Getting a good share from food, rather than supplements alone, is a reasonable everyday approach.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Chhum han, boiled mixed vegetables with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked beans (1 cup vegetables, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2) with a vegetable poha, flattened rice with peas and carrots (1 cup) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Bekang, fermented soybean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked soybeans) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. River fish curry, Mizo-style (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — If you're anaemic or your haemoglobin is low

If a blood test has flagged low haemoglobin, folate is one of several nutrients that could be involved. Ask your care team what your specific results point to rather than assuming folate is the answer and supplementing on your own.

Worth knowing: Anaemia has several possible causes. Which one applies to you can only be determined by assessment — a blood test guides which nutrient, if any, actually needs addressing; treating a guess with a supplement isn't a substitute for that.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Sawhchiar, rice-and-vegetable porridge with carrots (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked beans, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-onion paratha (2 eggs, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Bekang, fermented soybean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked soybeans) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

B. Chicken curry, Mizo-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer tikka, grilled spiced paneer skewers with capsicum and onion (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a cucumber-tomato salad

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — If another pregnancy might be ahead

This is different from the everyday folate covered elsewhere this week. If pregnancy is anywhere in your thinking, standard guidance is to start a daily 400 microgram folic acid supplement now, before trying — not to wait for a positive test. This guidance continues into the early weeks of pregnancy too, not just the run-up to conceiving; keep taking it once you know you're pregnant, until your care team advises otherwise. Raise it with your care team if you haven't already; this is worth acting on early rather than treating as a food-only question.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Bai with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked beans (1 cup stew, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-spinach toast (2 eggs, 2 slices) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Rajma, kidney bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a pumpkin sabzi

B. Chicken curry, Mizo-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a pumpkin sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a toor dal (3/4 cup)

B. Egg-and-potato curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Leafy greens, legumes and citrus — everyday sources

Spinach and other leafy greens, rajma and other beans, lentils, oranges and other citrus fruit, and fortified grains all contribute meaningfully to folate intake. None of them needs to be eaten daily on its own — these foods help contribute to your needs across a varied week.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Chhum han with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked beans (1 cup vegetables, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable uttapam, rice-and-lentil batter pancake with mixed vegetables (2 eggs, 2 pieces) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Chana masala, chickpea curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an aloo-palak sabzi
- B. Chicken curry, Mizo-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an aloo-palak sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a bottle-gourd sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across your week matters, not one meal

No single folate-rich food is carrying the whole week on its own — beans, greens, citrus and fortified grains showing up across your meals, rather than in one deliberate dish, is what actually adds up. There's no need to track this nutrient meal by meal if your overall diet is reasonably varied.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sawhchiar, rice-and-vegetable porridge (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked beans, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Bekang, fermented soybean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked soybeans) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans-and-carrot sabzi
- B. Chicken curry, Mizo-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans-and-carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut melon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted pumpkin seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a pumpkin sabzi
- B. Egg bhurji-stuffed roti wrap, spiced scrambled eggs rolled in chapati with onion and tomato (2 eggs, 2 chapati) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Bai, mixed vegetable stew with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked beans (1 cup stew, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg bhurji with tomato and onion, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Bekang, fermented soybean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked soybeans) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

B. Chicken curry, Mizo-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Which everyday folate source from this week — a green, a bean, a citrus fruit — would you actually keep eating regularly?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

Next week looks at something most households navigate without much thought: your own drinking water, and what "safe" actually means.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- A folate or folic acid supplement isn't a substitute for a blood test if anaemia is suspected — ask your care team which nutrient, if any, your results point to before starting one on your own.

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Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 122

REWORK v4 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Understanding your own drinking water — RO purifiers, TDS, and what "safe" means

"A TDS number on a purifier display tells you about dissolved minerals, not about germs — knowing what it does and doesn't measure helps you make sense of the reading rather than either ignoring it or over-worrying about it."

Why it matters now

Most households manage drinking water through some kind of purifier without thinking much about what it actually does. A TDS reading measures dissolved minerals and salts — a high or low number tells you about taste and mineral content, not about bacteria or viruses, and it cannot by itself establish that water is safe to drink. RO purification removes dissolved solids, including beneficial minerals, and very low TDS isn't automatically better; the World Health Organization hasn't set a health-based guideline value for TDS, and India's drinking water standard (IS 10500) treats it mainly as an acceptability and taste parameter rather than a safety threshold.

RO membranes can remove many microorganisms as well as dissolved minerals, but real-world performance depends on the specific system, how well it's maintained, and safe storage afterward — no single stage or technology is an unconditional guarantee against every contaminant. Knowing what your specific purifier is certified to remove, for your specific source water, matters more than a single brand claim or category label.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If you're on a low-sodium or fluid-restricted plan for a kidney or heart condition: ask your care team whether your household water's mineral content is something they want you to factor in — this varies by individual situation and isn't something to judge from a TDS number alone.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Malvani/Konkan coastal Maharashtrian cooking (sanna, amboli, sol kadi, usal, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

TDS stands for total dissolved solids — a measure of minerals and salts dissolved in water, not a measure of microbial safety. A high or low TDS reading tells you something about mineral content and taste, but it doesn't by itself tell you whether the water is free of bacteria or viruses. The two are different questions.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna, steamed rice cakes with coconut chutney (3 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with tomato and onion, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Usal, sprouted moth bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moth beans) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. Malvani chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — What RO purification actually does

Reverse osmosis (RO) purification removes dissolved salts and many contaminants, but it strips out beneficial minerals along with the unwanted ones — which is part of why RO water often reads a very low TDS. Very low TDS isn't automatically "more pure" or better for you: the World Health Organization hasn't set a health-based guideline value for TDS, and India's drinking water standard (IS 10500) treats it mainly as an acceptability and taste parameter, not a safety threshold. A TDS number, high or low, doesn't by itself establish that water is microbially or chemically safe.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Amboli, rice-and-coconut pancake with coconut chutney (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Masala omelette with tomato and onion (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Usal, sprouted moth bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moth beans) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Malvani fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of sol kadi, kokum-and-coconut milk drink (200ml)

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-vegetable stir-fry, sautéed paneer with mixed vegetables (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a cucumber raita

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Matching your purifier to your actual water source

The right purification approach depends on what's actually present in your source water, not on how it looks, tastes or feels — hardness or a strong taste don't by themselves tell you what treatment is needed, and their absence doesn't mean the water is safe either. A water-testing service can identify what's actually in your water; choose a purifier independently verified to remove those specific contaminants, rather than picking one based on taste, appearance, or marketing claims.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna with a sukka sabzi (3 pieces, 1 cup sabzi) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable dalia, broken wheat porridge with carrots and peas (2 eggs stirred in, 1 cup dalia) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Chana masala, chickpea curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a squash sabzi
- B. Malvani chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a squash sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot-and-peas sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Mineral content and microbial safety are different questions

A purifier's real-world performance against minerals and against microbes both depend on its specific components, upkeep and safe storage afterward — not simply on which broad category (RO, UV, ultrafiltration) it falls into. Checking what your specific system is certified to remove for your specific source water, and keeping it serviced, matters more than any single brand claim.

Worth knowing: RO membranes can remove many microorganisms, including bacteria and most viruses, when the system is intact and properly maintained — this isn't a job reserved exclusively for a UV or ultrafiltration stage. But no single stage or technology is an unconditional guarantee against every possible contaminant: actual performance depends on the specific system, how well it's maintained, and how the water is stored afterward. If your municipal supply is known to be microbially unsafe, check what your specific purifier is certified to remove, or use boiling as a fallback.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Amboli with a sukka sabzi (2 pieces, 1 cup sabzi) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-spinach toast (2 eggs, 2 slices) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Usal, sprouted moth bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moth beans) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi
- B. Malvani chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a toor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg-and-potato curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Filters and membranes need routine servicing

A purifier's filter cartridges and RO membrane lose effectiveness over time and need replacing on the schedule the manufacturer specifies, not just when the water starts tasting or looking different — by the time you notice a change, the filter may have been underperforming for a while. Keeping a simple record of when each part was last changed is a small habit that keeps the whole system doing what it's meant to.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna with coconut chutney (3 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rajma, kidney bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a papeta sabzi
- B. Bombil fry, Bombay duck fish fry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a papeta sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable biryani-style rice, spiced rice with boiled eggs and mixed vegetables (2 eggs, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — If you drank water from an uncertain source

If you drank water from an uncertain source, there is no need to blame yourself. Use reliably safe water going forward. Seek medical advice if you develop persistent vomiting, bloody diarrhoea, fever or signs of dehydration.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna, steamed rice cakes with a sukka sabzi (3 pieces, 1 cup sabzi) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2) with a vegetable-and-cheese toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Usal, sprouted moth bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moth beans) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi
- B. Malvani chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted pumpkin seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a squash sabzi
- B. Egg-and-onion curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna, steamed rice cakes with coconut chutney (3 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with tomato and onion, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Usal, sprouted moth bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moth beans) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. Malvani chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Do you know which purification stages your own household purifier actually has, and when the filters were last changed?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

Next week looks at a B vitamin that doesn't get much everyday attention: vitamin B6, and what it actually does for you.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- A TDS reading measures dissolved minerals — it does not by itself establish microbial safety, whether the number is high or low. RO can remove many microorganisms when properly maintained, but no single purification stage guarantees protection against every contaminant; check what your specific purifier is certified to remove for your source water.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 123

REWORK v4 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Vitamin B6 — a steady everyday nutrient, not a mood supplement to self-dose

"B6 supports protein metabolism, red blood cell formation and neurotransmitter production day to day — everyday foods help contribute to your needs, and supplemental B6 carries its own risk rather than being an automatic extra."

Why it matters now

Vitamin B6 supports protein metabolism, red blood cell formation and the everyday production of neurotransmitters. Most people get enough through ordinary meals — bananas, potatoes, legumes, whole grains, poultry and fish are all dependable sources, and none of them needs to appear in every meal to add up across a varied week.

B6 is sometimes marketed as a standalone supplement for mood or premenstrual symptoms, but supplemental B6 can cause nerve damage — including when several products (a multivitamin, a magnesium supplement, a B-complex) each contribute some B6 and add up without you realising it. Cases have been reported at lower supplemental doses too, particularly when products are combined; a minimum dose or duration associated with this reaction has not been established. Food sources don't carry this risk — it's specifically a supplement concern, and a reason to check labels and your total intake with your care team rather than a reason to be wary of B6-rich foods.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If you're on isoniazid or another medicine known to affect B6 levels: your prescriber may already have this factored into your treatment plan — confirm with them rather than adding your own B6 supplement on top of what's prescribed.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple,

reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Udupi / coastal Karnataka vegetarian cooking (idli, dosa, sambar, rasam, upma, palya, kosambari, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Vitamin B6 supports your body's protein metabolism, red blood cell production and the everyday synthesis of neurotransmitters. It's a nutrient most people get enough of through ordinary meals, without needing a dedicated supplement or a specially engineered dish.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Idli (4 pieces) with sambar and coconut chutney (1 cup sambar) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with tomato and onion, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Huli, lentil-and-vegetable curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a palya
- B. Chicken curry, coastal Karnataka-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a palya

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Everyday food sources

Bananas, potatoes, chickpeas and other legumes, poultry, fish and fortified cereals are all dependable B6 sources. None of them needs to appear in every meal — spread across a varied week, they help contribute to your needs without any special effort.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Masala dosa with a potato palya and coconut chutney (1 dosa, 1/2 cup potato filling) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable khichdi, rice-and-moong dal breakfast dish with mixed vegetables (2 eggs stirred in, 1 cup khichdi) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Chana huli, chickpea curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a palya
- B. Mangalorean-style fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a palya

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — If you're taking a B6-containing supplement

B6 is sometimes marketed as a standalone supplement for mood or premenstrual symptoms. Cases of nerve damage have been reported at lower supplemental doses too, particularly when products are combined — a minimum dose or duration associated with this reaction has not been established. Checking your total B6 intake from all supplements against your care team's advice is worth doing, whatever the individual doses.

Worth knowing: Supplemental B6 can cause nerve damage. Cases have been reported at lower supplemental doses too, particularly when products are combined — check multivitamin, magnesium and B-complex labels. If tingling, burning or numbness develops, stop non-prescribed B6-containing supplements and seek medical advice promptly. If B6 is prescribed as part of treatment, contact your prescriber promptly for instructions. This isn't a reason to avoid B6-rich foods — it's specifically about supplemental B6.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Rava upma with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion paratha (2 eggs, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Huli, lentil-and-vegetable curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans palya
- B. Chicken curry, coastal Karnataka-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans palya

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable stew, boiled eggs simmered with mixed vegetables in a light gravy (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a cabbage sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — If you take isoniazid or certain other medicines

A small number of medicines, including isoniazid (used for tuberculosis treatment) and some others, are known to lower the body's B6 levels over time. If you're on one of these, your prescriber may already have this covered with a specific B6 dose as part of your treatment plan — this is worth confirming with them rather than adding your own supplement on top of what's prescribed.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Idli with sambar and coconut chutney (4 pieces, 1 cup sambar) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-mushroom bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs with mushrooms and onion (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rajma, kidney bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a palya
- B. Mangalorean-style prawn curry (100g prawns) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a palya

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a toor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg-and-potato curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Whole grains and legumes, day to day

Whole grains, legumes and a modest variety of vegetables and fruit across the week form a dependable base for B6, alongside poultry and fish for those who eat them. These foods help contribute to your B6 needs without needing a dedicated tracking effort.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Avalakki, spiced flattened rice with peanuts (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Huli, lentil-and-vegetable curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a kosambari
- B. Chicken curry, coastal Karnataka-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a kosambari

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-methi curry, paneer with fenugreek leaves (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a beetroot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across your week matters, not one meal

No single B6-rich food is doing all the work on its own — bananas, potatoes, legumes, grains and, for those who eat them, poultry and fish, showing up across the week is what actually matters. There's no need to track this nutrient meal by meal if your overall diet is reasonably varied.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Rava upma with vegetables and roasted peanuts (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Huli, lentil-and-vegetable curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage palya
- B. Chicken curry, coastal Karnataka-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage palya

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted pumpkin seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a squash sabzi
- B. Egg-and-onion curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Idli (4 pieces) with sambar and coconut chutney (1 cup sambar) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with tomato and onion, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Huli, lentil-and-vegetable curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a palya
- B. Chicken curry, coastal Karnataka-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a palya

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Which everyday B6 source from this week — a banana, a legume dish, a grain — would you actually keep eating regularly?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

Next week takes a step back to look at your own plate as a whole — putting together everything this series has covered about balance, rather than one nutrient at a time.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- Supplemental B6 can cause nerve damage, including when several products containing it are combined — check multivitamin, magnesium and B-complex labels for your total intake. If tingling, burning or numbness develops, stop non-prescribed B6-containing supplements and seek medical advice promptly.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 124

REWORK v4 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Putting it together — your own balanced plate, revisited

"A balanced plate isn't about hitting perfect proportions at every single meal — it's a dependable protein source, a dependable calcium source, a grain, and vegetables or fruit, showing up across your day."

Why it matters now

This series has repeated the same handful of building blocks since its earliest weeks: a dependable protein source, a dependable calcium source, a grain, and vegetables or fruit, spread across the day rather than crammed into one meal. This week doesn't introduce a new nutrient — it's a practical pause to see how those pieces fit together in an ordinary day's eating.

None of the individual pieces needs to be perfect at every meal. Protein, calcium, grains and produce adding up across several days is what actually matters, and there's more than one valid way to cover each one.

A balanced plate like this is about giving your body what it needs to function well — enough energy for your day, the building blocks for strength and recovery — rather than being framed around a weight outcome. If weight is something you're thinking about, that's a personal choice to raise with your own care team; this series isn't offering a weight-management plan, and eating adequately here isn't in tension with whatever goals you're working toward.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are

meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Anglo-Indian cooking (kedgeree, dalcha, railway curry, country captain, ball curry, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

This series has repeated the same handful of building blocks since Week 43: a dependable protein source, a dependable calcium source, a grain, and vegetables or fruit. None of that has changed — this week is simply about seeing how those pieces fit together across an ordinary day, rather than learning something new.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable kedgeree, rice-and-lentil breakfast dish (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with tomato and onion, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Dalcha, dal-and-vegetable curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi
- B. Country captain chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Protein — several valid sources, not one right answer

Dal and other legumes, paneer, tofu, eggs, meat and fish are all valid protein sources — different in nutrient profile and not interchangeable at the same portion size, but each a legitimate way to cover this building block. There's no single "correct" protein for every meal, only what suits your appetite, budget and dietary choices that day.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Devilled potato toast, spiced mashed potato on toast (2 slices) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Masala omelette with tomato and onion (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Chana dalcha, chickpea-and-vegetable curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Railway mutton curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable cutlets, spiced patties with mashed vegetables and egg (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a tomato-onion salad

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Calcium — the two-a-day habit this series keeps returning to

The calcium habit repeated across this series — curd, milk or paneer at more than one meal, or a measured fortified alternative if you avoid dairy — is the same one that applies here. It's worth keeping even in a week that isn't specifically about calcium, since it's easy to let slip once the topic isn't front and centre.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Vegetable kedgeree with peas (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-capsicum paratha, stuffed flatbread with spiced egg and capsicum filling (2 eggs, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Moong dalcha, moong dal-and-vegetable curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a squash sabzi

B. Country captain chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a squash sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot-and-peas sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Vegetables and fruit — variety, not one "superfood"

No single vegetable or fruit needs to carry the whole week — different colours and types across your meals cover a broader range of nutrients than repeating the same one, however nutritious it is on its own. Whatever's seasonal, affordable and easy to prepare is a completely reasonable way to choose.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Bread (2 slices) and vegetable stew (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-spinach toast (2 eggs, 2 slices) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Rajma, kidney bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a pumpkin sabzi

B. Fish curry, Anglo-Indian-style (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a pumpkin sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a toor dal (3/4 cup)

B. Egg-and-potato curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Grains — whole where practical, portioned either way

Whole grains can help increase fibre intake. Choose them when practical; refined grains can also fit. Adjust portions to your needs rather than treating one amount as right for everyone.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Vegetable kedgeree with carrots (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Boiled eggs (2) with a vegetable upma, semolina with carrots and peas (1 cup) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Toor dalcha, toor dal-and-vegetable curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

B. Ball curry, spiced mutton meatball curry (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a bottle-gourd sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across your week matters, not one plate

No single meal needs to contain every building block covered this week — protein, calcium, grains, vegetables and fruit adding up across several days is what actually matters, not any one plate ticking every box. This is the same idea this series has repeated from the start, applied one more time.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Bread (2 slices) and vegetable stew with peas (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-tomato bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Dalcha, dal-and-vegetable curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi

B. Country captain chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted pumpkin seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a squash sabzi

B. Paneer-and-corn curry, paneer with sweet corn and tomato (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a cucumber salad

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Vegetable kedgeree, rice-and-lentil breakfast dish (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with tomato and onion, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Dalcha, dal-and-vegetable curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi
- B. Country captain chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Looking back at this week, which building block — protein, calcium, grains, or vegetables and fruit — comes together most naturally for you, and which one takes more deliberate effort?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

Next week looks at a nutrient with a genuinely India-specific angle: vitamin D, sunlight, and what that means in practice for your own bones and muscle function.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 125

REWORK v4 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Vitamin D — plenty of sunlight doesn't automatically mean enough of it

"Vitamin D supports your bones alongside calcium and plays a role in general wellbeing, but abundant sunshine where you live doesn't guarantee your body is making enough of it — a testable, addressable gap rather than something to assume either way."

Why it matters now

Vitamin D supports your bones alongside calcium and plays a broader role in general wellbeing. Despite India's abundant sunlight, deficiency is genuinely common — skin covering, mostly indoor routines, pollution, sunscreen use and darker skin tones all reduce how much vitamin D your skin actually makes from sun exposure. Sunshine alone cannot establish your vitamin D status one way or the other.

Testing is useful in selected circumstances, but routine testing isn't recommended for every otherwise healthy adult without a reason to test — this is different from monitoring a diagnosed deficiency or an existing supplement dose. Your clinician can advise whether testing, supplementation or monitoring makes sense for you. Food sources are also genuinely limited — fatty fish, egg yolks and fortified foods are the main ones, unlike several other nutrients this series has covered.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If you have a kidney condition or a history of high blood calcium: ask your care team before starting a vitamin D supplement — your situation may call for closer monitoring or a different dose than the general guidance here.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still

hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Tripuri cooking (muya/bamboo shoot and similar preparations). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Vitamin D works alongside calcium to support your bones, and plays a broader role in general wellbeing too. Despite India's abundant sunlight, vitamin D deficiency is common — skin covering, mostly indoor daily routines, pollution and sunscreen use all reduce how much your skin actually makes. Sunlight availability alone doesn't establish your own status — testing is useful in selected circumstances, and your clinician can advise whether it's worth doing for you rather than it being a routine default.

Worth knowing: Use commercially prepared bamboo shoots and follow the package instructions. Do not use raw or inadequately prepared fresh shoots.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Rice-and-vegetable porridge (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with tomato and onion, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Muya, bamboo shoot-and-lentil curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a mustard greens sabzi
- B. Chicken curry, Tripuri-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a mustard greens sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Why sunlight availability isn't the whole picture

Living somewhere sunny doesn't automatically translate into good vitamin D status — most of your day is likely spent indoors or with skin covered, and darker skin tones need more sun exposure to make the same amount. Deliberately increasing unprotected sun exposure isn't the preferred way to address a diagnosed low level, given the skin-cancer risk that comes with it — food or a properly guided supplement is the safer route. Keep your usual sun protection; sunscreen isn't something to skip on the theory that it's helping your vitamin D status.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Muya, bamboo shoot-and-vegetable stir-fry with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stir-fry, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Masala omelette with tomato and onion (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Muya, bamboo shoot-and-lentil curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. Mutton curry, Tripuri-style (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-broccoli stir-fry, sautéed paneer with broccoli and capsicum (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Food sources are genuinely limited

Unlike several nutrients covered elsewhere in this series, vitamin D isn't found reliably in a wide range of everyday foods — fatty fish, egg yolks and fortified milk or cereals are the main dietary sources, and even a good diet often doesn't fully close the gap on its own. This is one of the few nutrients where food alone commonly isn't enough, which is part of why supplementation, guided by your own clinician, plays a bigger role here than for most other nutrients in this series — not because everyone needs routine testing, but because diet is a less complete safety net for this particular nutrient.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Rice-and-vegetable porridge with peas (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion paratha (2 eggs, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Muya, bamboo shoot-and-lentil curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a squash sabzi
- B. Fish curry, Tripuri-style (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a squash sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot-and-peas sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — More isn't automatically better here either

Excessive vitamin D supplementation can raise blood calcium and cause harm. Do not self-prescribe high-dose treatment. Your clinician can advise on the appropriate dose and whether blood tests or monitoring are needed. Routine testing is not automatically needed for otherwise healthy adults taking ordinary recommended amounts.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Muya, bamboo shoot-and-vegetable stir-fry with carrots and rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stir-fry, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2) with a vegetable idli, steamed rice-and-lentil cakes with grated carrot (3 pieces) and a small bowl of curd (150g)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rajma, kidney bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a pumpkin sabzi
- B. Chicken curry, Tripuri-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a pumpkin sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a toor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg-and-potato curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Understanding your own supplement label

If you take a vitamin D supplement, it's worth knowing what's actually on the label — the concentration (often written as IU or micrograms per drop, tablet or dose), how often you're meant to take it, and whether any other product you're already taking (a multivitamin, a calcium-and-vitamin-D combination) also contains vitamin D. Duplicate products stacking on top of each other, without realising it, is an easy way to end up on a higher dose than intended. If anything on the label is unclear, your pharmacist can talk you through it.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Rice-and-vegetable porridge with carrots (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-tomato sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Chana masala, chickpea curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

B. Chicken curry, Tripuri-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a bottle-gourd sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across your week matters, not one sunny afternoon

A single sunny walk or one vitamin D-rich meal isn't what determines your status one way or the other — it builds up gradually over time, not from any single day's sun exposure or meal.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Rice-and-vegetable porridge with pumpkin (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-spinach bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs with spinach and onion (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Muya, bamboo shoot-and-lentil curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi

B. Egg curry, Tripuri-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted pumpkin seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a squash sabzi

B. Egg-and-vegetable pulao, lightly spiced rice with boiled eggs and mixed vegetables (2 eggs, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Rice-and-vegetable porridge (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji with tomato and onion, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Muya, bamboo shoot-and-lentil curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a mustard greens sabzi
- B. Chicken curry, Tripuri-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a mustard greens sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-capsicum curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Was there anything about your own sun exposure, diet or supplement routine this week that felt worth adjusting?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

Next week closes this run with a nutrient tied closely to blood clotting: vitamin K, and where it fits in your own diet.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- Use commercially prepared bamboo shoots and follow the package instructions — raw or inadequately prepared fresh bamboo shoots carry naturally occurring compounds that need proper processing to be safe.
- Routine vitamin D supplementation at an ordinary dose doesn't require automatic testing — that's different from treating a diagnosed deficiency, where excessive supplementation can raise blood calcium and cause harm. Do not self-prescribe high-dose treatment; have your clinician set and, where appropriate, monitor the dose. Use only the product and dose intended for you.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 126

REWORK v4 — correction for review, original remains locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Vitamin K — a steady everyday nutrient, and one worth mentioning if you're on blood thinners

"Vitamin K supports your body's normal blood clotting, drawn from both leafy greens and some fermented and animal foods — a quiet, everyday nutrient, though if you take warfarin or another vitamin K antagonist, steady, consistent intake matters more than any single meal."

Why it matters now

Vitamin K supports your body's normal blood clotting. It comes in two dietary forms that both contribute — K1, mainly from leafy green vegetables, and K2, found in some fermented foods and animal products, though content varies and isn't something to track separately from K1. For most people, a varied vegetable pattern across the week helps meet this need without any deliberate tracking, making it one of the more forgiving nutrients this series has covered.

If you take warfarin or another vitamin K antagonist, this is genuinely worth planning around — the usual guidance is consistency in how much you eat from day to day, not avoidance. If that doesn't apply to you, this week's meals need no special adjustment beyond the general pattern this series already encourages.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If you take warfarin or another vitamin K antagonist: keep your vitamin K intake fairly consistent from day to day rather than avoiding these foods, and talk to the clinician managing your medication before making any significant change to how much you eat.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple,

reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Zeliangrong hill-tribe cooking (axone/fermented soybean, smoked meats, bamboo shoot and leafy greens). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Vitamin K plays a central role in normal blood clotting. It comes in two dietary forms — K1, mainly from leafy green vegetables, and K2, found in some fermented foods and animal products, with content that varies — and both contribute. For most people, eating a variety of vegetables through the week helps meet this need without any special planning.

Worth knowing: Use commercially prepared bamboo shoots and follow the package instructions. Do not use raw or inadequately prepared fresh shoots.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Axone-tempered vegetable stir-fry with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stir-fry, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg bhurji with tomato and onion, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Mustard greens-and-lentil curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bamboo shoot sabzi

B. Smoked chicken curry, Zeliangrong-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bamboo shoot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted soybeans (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer-and-spinach curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Two dietary forms, both counting toward the same role

K1, from leafy greens like spinach, mustard greens and other vegetables, and K2, from some fermented soy foods and meats (content varies and isn't worth tracking on its own), both support the same clotting function — you don't need to track them separately or favour one over the other. A varied vegetable and food pattern across the week helps meet both.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Axone-tempered vegetable stir-fry with spinach and rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stir-fry, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-tomato omelette roll, rolled omelette with tomato and onion in a chapati (2 eggs, 1 chapati) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Mustard greens-and-lentil curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a squash sabzi

B. Mutton curry, smoked and spiced, Zeliangrong-style (100g mutton) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a squash sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi

B. Egg curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — If you take warfarin or another vitamin K antagonist

If this applies to you, consistency is the goal, not avoidance — a stable day-to-day pattern of vegetable intake is easier for your care team to manage around than swinging between very little and a lot.

Worth knowing: Warfarin and other vitamin K antagonist medications work by affecting how your body uses vitamin K, so this is a genuinely different situation from general dietary advice — it's specific to this class of medication, not anticoagulants generally. The usual guidance is not to avoid vitamin K-rich foods, but to keep your intake fairly consistent from day to day — a sudden large increase or decrease in leafy greens is more likely to affect your INR than steady, moderate intake. Talk to the clinician managing your medication before making any significant change to how much of these foods you eat.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Rice porridge (a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice, a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils, and a separately measured 1/2 cup cooked vegetables; add water as needed, finished volume varies) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion paratha (2 eggs, 2 paratha) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rajma, kidney bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked rajma) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a pumpkin sabzi
- B. Chicken curry, Zeliangrong-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a pumpkin sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-beans curry, paneer with french beans and tomato (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a beetroot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Everyday sources, without needing to plan around them

Leafy greens, some fermented soy foods, and a well-rounded mix of vegetables through the week help most people meet their vitamin K needs without any deliberate tracking — this is one of the more forgiving nutrients in this series for anyone not on a vitamin K antagonist.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Axone-tempered vegetable stir-fry with cabbage and rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stir-fry, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable sevai, vermicelli with mixed vegetables and scrambled egg (2 eggs, 1 cup sevai) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Chana masala, chickpea curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Fish curry, Rongmei-style (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Egg-and-potato curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a beans sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — An easy leafy-green addition to your own meal

You don't need to eat leafy greens at every meal to cover your vitamin K needs, but adding a small serving somewhere in the day — a handful of spinach stirred into a curry, mustard greens as a side, or coriander and other herbs scattered over a dish — is a simple, low-effort way to build in some variety without a dedicated dish.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Chana masala, chickpea curry with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana (1 cup curry, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Mustard greens-and-lentil curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi
- B. Chicken curry, Zeliangrong-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a ridge-gourd sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with an urad dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Egg-and-spinach curry, boiled eggs simmered in a spiced spinach gravy (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across your week matters, not one meal

One especially green-heavy meal, or one day without any leafy vegetables, doesn't meaningfully change your vitamin K status either way — it's the overall pattern across the week, not any single plate, that matters here. If you take warfarin or another vitamin K antagonist, this general reassurance doesn't override the day-to-day consistency your care team is tracking (see Day 3) — the pattern that matters for you is steadier and shorter than a week.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Axone-tempered vegetable stir-fry with carrots and rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stir-fry, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Mustard greens-and-lentil curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans-and-carrot sabzi
- B. Egg curry, Zeliangrong-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans-and-carrot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted pumpkin seeds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a squash sabzi
- B. Egg-and-onion curry (2 eggs) with roti (2 pieces) and a cabbage-and-carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Axone-tempered vegetable stir-fry with rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils (1 cup stir-fry, 1 cup rice) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg bhurji with tomato and onion, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Mustard greens-and-lentil curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked lentils) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bamboo shoot sabzi

B. Smoked chicken curry, Zeliangrong-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bamboo shoot sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted soybeans (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Roti (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer-and-spinach curry (100g paneer) with roti (2 pieces) and a mixed vegetable sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Looking back across this run of weeks, which single change has made the most noticeable difference to how you feel day to day?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- Use commercially prepared bamboo shoots and follow the package instructions — raw or inadequately prepared fresh bamboo shoots carry naturally occurring compounds that need proper processing to be safe.
- If you take warfarin or another vitamin K antagonist, keep your intake of vitamin K-rich foods fairly consistent from day to day rather than avoiding them, and check with the clinician managing your medication before making a significant change.